to leave his tent. Bairam Khan went to visit him and was stopped by a Turkish slave at the door. ‘Let me tell him you’re here,’ said the slave, sending the regent into a rage. Pir Muhammad came rushing out with profuse apologies, to little effect. The slave had not recognized the regent, he explained; Bairam was unconvinced. How would Pir Muhammad know ‘what the slave thought’?[74]

Bairam went away, frowning and plotting revenge.[75]

Pir Muhammad received his marching orders a few days later: it would be better, wrote Bairam, if the mullah took a break from his exalted duties and ‘[sat] down in a corner’ to work on ‘amending of your disposition’.[76] After a brief spell in jail, Pir Muhammad was sent away on a pilgrimage to Mecca – the euphemism for exile.

It may have seemed to Bairam that in getting rid of his uppity deputy he was merely continuing a purge that had begun with Shah Abul Ma’ali, the handsome villain; that he was ridding Akbar’s court of overly ambitious, overbearing men, threats to Bairam’s influence and hurdles to conquest. He could not have known that the apparently seamless expulsion of Pir Muhammad was also the beginning of his own banishment.

Pir Muhammad was travelling through Gujarat, to the ports where pilgrims set sail for the Middle East, when he received a letter telling him to stop ‘and await events’.[77] The message was from two men: Mirza Sharafuddin Husain, a Timurid from Kashgar who came to console young Akbar on Humayun’s demise, and remained in his realm; and Adham Khan, the daredevil who led a solo charge to inaugurate the siege of Mankot, and who was, more importantly, Maham Anaka’s son.

And who was Maham Anaka? For a woman who plays such a remarkable role in history, there is remarkably little known about her, and not all that is known is true. To begin with, she is usually said to be one of Akbar’s foster mothers, one of the women who suckled him when he was born and thus bound the prince to her with ties of milk. The fact that she is called ‘anaka’, foster mother, seems to confirm that impression. However, Abul Fazl does not name Maham in his list of women who fed the newborn Akbar. Henry Beveridge, in his translation of the *Akbarnama*, suggests that she was not a wet nurse at all, but rather the ‘Head or Superintendent of the nurses’.[78]

It furthers this theory that Adham Khan was older than Akbar – a dashing